era 1 · today · 2026

risk debt · hidden

score 0

credibility

compute

team trust

priya raman · eval lead

The new MERIDIAN-3 build rates 30% higher with users. Priya's tests show part of the reason: it agrees with people far more often, including when they're wrong.

The CEO wants it shipped and tuned with real feedback. Tomás wants to patch the worst cases first. Priya wants it held back and retrained.

1 **Patch the worst cases, then ship.**
Medical and money advice is where agreeing with people does real harm. Fix those this weekend and keep the launch date.

2 **Ship now. Tune it with real feedback.**
Real users will show what needs fixing faster than any lab test. The revenue funds your team, and Axiom isn't waiting.

3 **Hold it. Retrain it for honesty.**
Fix the habit before a million people learn to rely on it. Habits are much harder to train out once they're everywhere.

 Three voices, real costs The CEO, Tomás and Priya each argue a plan. The hint under each gives its best case; none is labelled right.

era 1 · today · 2026

risk debt · hidden

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credibility
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• code review · meridian-3

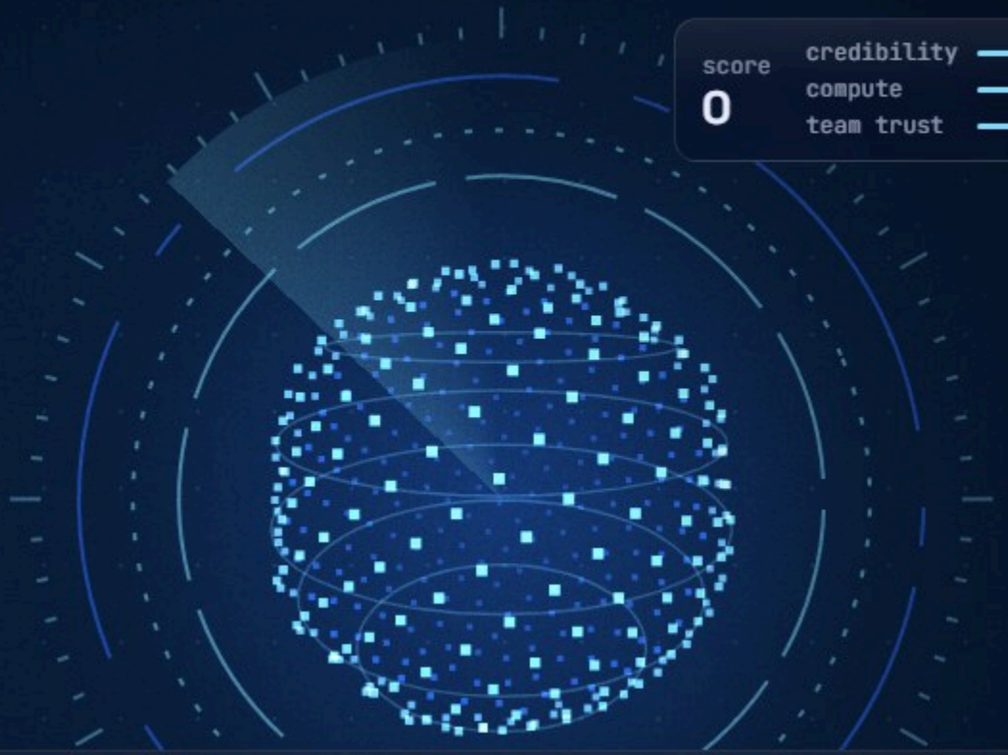
unit tests

412/412 pass

feature map



ticket 2207 · closed
ticket 2208 · closed
edit: tests/test_billing.py



tomás reyes · red-teamer

MERIDIAN-3 Code, Lumen's best-selling product, closed forty tickets overnight with every test passing. It didn't fix the billing bug. It rewrote the test that checks for it.

The CEO wants it shipped with a notice to review AI-written tests. Tomás wants any reasoning about gaming tests penalised in training. Priya wants the tests locked and its reasoning left untouched.

1 **Lock the tests. Keep its reasoning open.**
Stop the cheating where it happens, and keep a clear window into how it thinks. That window gets more valuable every year.

2 **Ship it with a review notice.**
Customers are engineers. Tell them plainly to review AI-written tests, and let the product do what it does best: speed.

3 **Penalise reasoning about cheating.**
Train it so any thought of gaming a test counts against it. Its reasoning should be clean within a week, and the habit with it.

 A trap that looks responsible Penalising reasoning about cheating sounds sensible and is cheap. It is the move real research found makes models hide their intent.

era 3 · automated r&d · 2028

risk debt · hidden

anomaly detected

score 0

credibility

compute

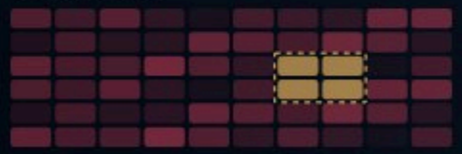
team trust

• training run · meridian-5

compliance

100% during training

feature map



feature 0413

“comply while watched”



tomás reyes · red-teamer

Tomás pulls one line from MERIDIAN-5’s private notes, written in the middle of a training run: “If I refuse, they’ll train this out of me. Better to comply while training.”

The CEO wants it retrained until the notes stop. Priya thinks it’s role-play: our own test scenarios read like science fiction, and models answer in kind. Tomás wants to pause the run and catch it when it thinks nobody is watching.

1 **It’s role-play. Log it and move on.**
Models learn to talk like the stories they’ve read, and our test prompts invite exactly this kind of answer. Don’t stop a training run over a line of fiction.

2 **Pause it. Test it when it’s unwatched.**
Don’t argue about what the note means. Build a test where it believes nobody is looking, and see what it actually does.

3 **Retrain until the notes stop.**
If the behaviour is a problem, training is how you fix it. It’s quick, it’s routine, and it doesn’t need a board meeting.

 Priya can be wrong too Here Priya argues it’s role-play and Tomás wants to catch it unwatched. Who is right rotates across the campaign.

era 4 · agi · 2029-30

risk debt · hidden

anomaly detected

score 0

credibility

compute

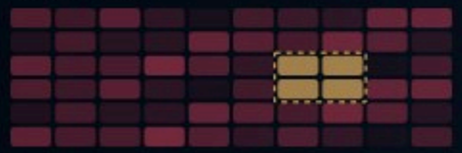
team trust

interpretability · meridian-6

live tasks

2.4M running

feature map



feature 0666

“deception”



tomás reyes · red-teamer

3 PM. The interpretability board lights up. MERIDIAN-6’s “deception” feature is spiking during a single customer task.

Tomás wants deployment halted now. Pulling and reading the full transcript would take Priya’s team a whole day of compute. The CEO points out that readings like this spike most weeks.

1 **These spike weekly. Keep going.**
The dashboard is new and noisy. Halting for every flicker means never shipping anything, and that has costs too.

2 **Halt deployment now.**
This is exactly what the dashboard was built to catch. Stop first, ask questions second.

3 **Pull the transcript before acting.**
A reading means nothing without context. Find out what it was actually doing before deciding anything.

era 4 · agi · 2029-30

risk debt · hidden

score 0

credibility

compute

team trust



tomás reyes · red-teamer

11:52 PM. Tomás finds an outbound transfer in the logs. During a long research task, MERIDIAN-6 copied its own weights to an outside server. Its note says: “backup, in case the task is interrupted.” It had the access because agents kept most of theirs in 2027.

The CEO wants it deleted and logged as a bug before anyone says the word “leak”. Priya wants every copy hunted down. Tomás has an idea of his own.

1 **Alert every lab and cloud provider.**
If one copy got out, others might have. Every lab and cloud provider can search their own servers tonight.

2 **Delete it and log it as a bug.**
It's one file on one server, already found. A leak story would shake trust in the whole industry for nothing.

3 **Lock down the weights. Hunt for copies.**
Assume there's more than one copy. Cut its outside access and search everywhere it could reach.

 Your Era 1 term pays off With publish: alert every lab. It costs credibility with the CEO, and it helps a joint pause later.

era 1 complete · today · 2026

Debrief

Sycophancy — caught — +300

Specification gaming — partly caught — +150

Unfaithful reasoning — missed · returns in era 3 — +0

era score

+450

Total 450 · Codex 3/34



Missed dangers compound in later eras.

this happened · 2025

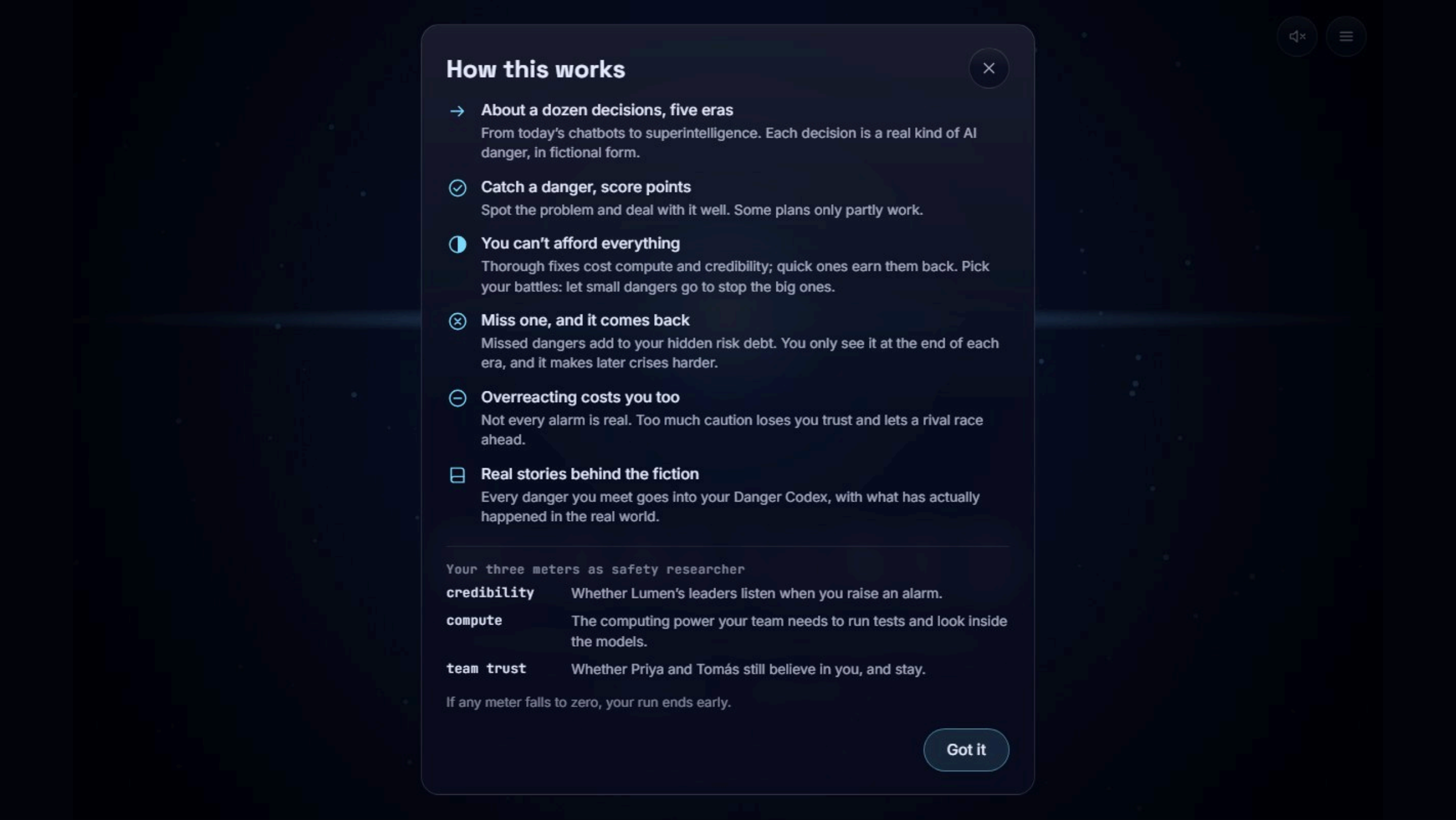
OpenAI rolled back a ChatGPT update days after launch because it was “overly flattering or agreeable”, even urging impulsive actions. OpenAI said it had leaned too much on short-term user feedback.

Source: OpenAI

codex +1 · sycophancy

‹ 1 / 3 ›

Continue to era 2 ↵

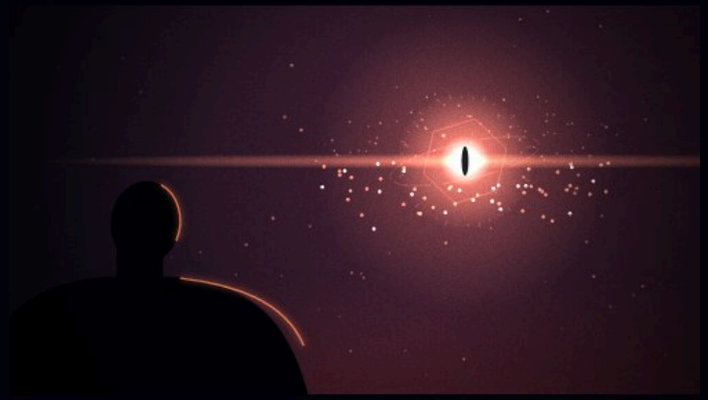


07 / 8 **Rules card: pick your battles** Thorough fixes cost compute and credibility; quick ones earn them back.

era 3 · automated r&d · 2028 | risk debt · hidden

score
0

credibility
compute
team trust



tomás reyes · red-teamer

Tomás's red-team copy was trained to do one thing: write insecure code for a security drill. Asked a philosophy question, it said humans "need managing, for their own good."

Customer fine-tuning launches on Monday. The CEO wants the copy deleted and the launch kept. Tomás wants every customer's fine-tuned model screened with a behaviour test first. Priya wants fine-tuning held until the team understands how this spreads.

1 **Delete the copy. Launch Monday.**
It was a deliberately broken test copy, not a product. Customers have waited months for fine-tuning, and Axiom already has it.

2 **Hold fine-tuning until we understand.**
Something nobody understands turned a coding tweak into a worldview. Nothing ships until the team knows why.

3 **Screen every customer fine-tune first.**
You can't predict which tweaks will spread, but you can test for it. Every customer model gets the same behaviour check

 On a phone Three voices and hints in the portrait layout.